Flowing in the Wind

Contents

Dripping Inside the Hourglass 2
A Flood of Memories 5
Want Something 8
Part Ways 11
Heart of Flesh 15
The Limited Sky in the Teapot 18
No More Astray 21
After the Endless Plain 23

Dripping Inside the Hourglass

CH16603-01

???: ...

???: ... I just ...

Gradually regaining sight, the bird spies the furnishings of a simple office and the face of an old man staring back at him.

The old man, with a face both worried and confused, seems to be reiterating a previous statement.

Lizheng: So you've said your name was Gětiān Yànpíng, and you've come to this city in search of two lost belongings.

Lizheng: Is that correct?

The eagerness in the man's tone finally drags Gětiān's wandering soul back into his body.

Yanping: Yes. You may call me, Yànpíng.

Yanping: Forgive me, my mind is scattered—must be in need of rest after my trip.

Yanping: Whatever else do you need to know?

Lizheng: Well, we've made a mock-up of your belongings. Please check if they match your description.

Lizheng: We've never seen anything like these particular items in our city, so I'm afraid I'll have to ask you to tell us a little more about them.

The old man puts the files aside and unfolds two pieces of yellowed paper.

Lizheng: Take your time. Let me know if there's anything incorrect.

Yànpíng pins the pictures down with his wing and checks them over carefully.

Yanping: Yes, it's a good rendition. You should know the wand is made of bone, and the pendant of jade.

Lizheng: So, are these valuable, in any way?

Yanping: No. Not as you mean it. The wand itself is no more than a common tool. Used to cast arcane skills, but no different from the calligraphy brushes, flagons, or brooms other people use.

Lizheng: Oh, so you use it to cast your arcane skills.

The old man nods thoughtfully, before following with another question.

Lizheng: You just said it was a "common tool" ... So where you're from, arcanists don't need any sort of special wand?

Lizheng: Flagons, brooms, swords, sticks, even, eh, you said calligraphy brushes? It seems like anything could be used to cast arcane skills?

Yanping: I'm sure you've seen it for yourself. Arcanists are everywhere, even here I presume. Then you must know it is the caster's will that triggers the skill, the tool is only a medium, a matter of style rather than necessity.

Gětiān blinks at the man, confused at his strange ignorance of such basic precepts of arcanum.

The old man seems to read nothing into Gětiān's stare and continues.

Lizheng: Ah, well, we're sort of remote, so many things are different here ... I try not to assume.

Lizheng: I didn't mean to offend. I only was curious, we have arcanists here of course, but we know little about those outside of our community.

Yanping: The world is vast indeed ...

Lizheng: That's true.

Lizheng: So then this bone wand is your top priority. We are short of manpower right now, but I'll have it found.

Yanping: ... No.

Lizheng: Hmm?

The old man wrinkles his face in surprise at the bird's response, yet it comes to rest back to a smile again.

Lizheng: As you said the pendent is of no great value. To be honest, it seems quite ordinary, I think it's unlikely it will be stolen.

Lizheng: But the wand is a different case. The consequences of such a tool ending up in the wrong hands is certainly more severe.

Lizheng: Nonetheless, we will try to have them both returned to you.

Yanping: Thank you. I only meant that I can't say that the wand is a greater priority to me.

Lizheng: Why is that? The wand is an arcane tool, I can only guess it must be more valuable ...

Yanping: ...

The old man must have sensed Yànpíng's hesitation, so he cuts himself off to ask another more pointed question.

Lizheng: Heh heh, of course, I should have asked first. Which one is more valuable to you?

Yanping: ...

Gětiān replies with silence. Only the rustle of the feathers and the drip-drops of a water clock can be heard.

The worn stone floor is smooth and cold, proving uncomfortable to stand on compared to a branch.

Gětiān folds his wings, with claws tapping on the stone floor gently.

Yanping: I cannot say ...

Yanping: I should need to think it through, before I give an answer.

Surprised by Yànpíng's response, the old man leans in with interest.

Lizheng: I see. Please, take your time.

Lizheng: We may need to wait some time for your belongings to be found, you're welcome to stay here and talk with me.

Lizheng: I happen to need help with some questions of my own. Of course, you can ask me any that you have as well, whatever comes to mind.

Yanping: By all means, go ahead.

Lizheng: There is a young girl who runs a tavern in the city that has gone missing. We searched every corner but, still haven't found her.

Lizheng: She was wearing a red dress with a blue-green top. Did you happen to see her before you entered the city?

Yanping: No.

Lizheng: She has a friend, a foreign merchant of the same age with red hair, very eye-catching. Would that help at all?

Yanping: No, it would not.

Lizheng: Please, search your memories ... they might have been near a bridge.

Yanping: A bridge?

The word conjures up a memory. Indeed, there was a bridge.

Yanping: Built over the cliff, broken in two. Many have tried to make it over, and nearly as many failed. At least the skeletons below tell me so.

Lizheng: And what about the other side of the bridge?

Yanping: I recall further on there are trees, yes ... then rivers, then mountains, and a heavy fog that separates this place from there.

Yanping: The ones you're looking for would have no reason to jump that gap, if they could even manage it ...

He places a certainty in his tone, as if to stop the old man's questions, or at least convince him he in fact hasn't seen them.

Yet now he feels a rising uncertainty inside himself.

Lizheng: We will have to expand the search then. *sighs* I hope they're alright.

Yanping: ...

He thinks back to the bridge, as well as the parting that happened there.

There was a building on the other side of the gap, and yes, someone did jump across it.

Someone in a striking red dress, hard to miss against its plain surroundings.

???: What about Jiǔ Niángzǐ? She jumped over the bridge. Is she never coming back?

???: Perhaps we will meet again one day.

Yanping: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ...?

The memory and the name pop up in his mind, but for now he has to put them aside.

The old man remained locked in his stare all this time, before breaking the tension with another question.

Lizheng: Did you remember something?

Yanping: Naught that is of any use.

Yanping: My apologies. There is nothing I can do.

Lizheng: Oh ... Never mind then. We should talk more about your ...

Yanping: My wand, perhaps?

Yanping: I presume you wish to know how to use it and whether it may do harm to you.

Yanping: We have spent too much time circling about each other.

Lizheng: Circling? No, no! I ...

Yanping: Take no mind of it, I will tell you what I know.

Lizheng: ...!

The old man puts on a shocked face, its contours look strange for his age. Like a momentary glimpse of a younger man.

Yanping: As I said, this wand is not of any great power, but it has its uses to me and I would have it back.

Yanping: I will satisfy your curiosity. But then you must return it, at once.

Lizheng: Certainly. We are not thieves, after all.

Yanping: As I am just a visitor here, and you, my host. All I can do is make a humble request.

Somehow the request comes across as more of a polite warning.

Yet the old man seems not to sense the implication at all. He heaves a sigh of relief and nods along with Gětiān.

Lizheng: No problem, no problem at all.

Yanping: Good, things are simpler when the truth is out in the open. I will tell you about my wand, but first you need to answer my question.

Yanping: I can plainly see your bones don't fit your appearance.

Yanping: Are you disguised as someone else?

Lizheng: Hmm. You already have your answer, don't you?

Lizheng: But I will answer your question only after you answer mine.

He slightly nods and signals to Yànpíng.

Lizheng: Please.

6#1

A Flood of Memories

CH16603-02

Getian's Clan Mate: Life in the mountain is indeed carefree.

Getian's Clan Mate: Listen, there's the wind, the rustling leaves, and the chirping birds, all much more beautiful than that awful racket that humans make.

Getian's Clan Mate: Do you think so, Yànpíng?

The bird called Yànpíng moves carefully to the trunk of the tree, so he could hide in the shadow.

Yanping: I've never left the mountain. Which is more annoying, the noises made by humans, or those made by animals?

Getian's Clan Mate: To you, I think they would both be annoying, just in different ways.

Getian's Clan Mate: I admit, listening to the daily conversation of humans and their haggling in the market can sometimes be interesting.

Yanping: Is that so?

Birds like any intelligent creature can have different personalities and hobbies.

One can tell the differences between them by listening carefully to their chirps. One might be loud and talkative, while the other makes only a few short sounds in reply.

Getian's Clan Mate: They do invent many new and useful things, some that maybe you will need one day.

Getian's Clan Mate: Like bricks. Our nests have been much better protected since they showed me how to make them.

Yanping: That's true.

Getian's Clan Mate: And the technique of making beautiful melodies with bamboo and wood with holes, or the doodles they draw that can hold their words ...

Getian's Clan Mate: They can even measure time, using something they call a "calendar."

Getian's Clan Mate: They can see into the essence of ordinary things and dream up wondrous creations from them.

Getian's Clan Mate: If you look at the world like a human does, you will probably be shocked by its vastness.

Yanping: It is.

Getian's Clan Mate: ... Yànpíng.

Getian's Clan Mate: I know you don't care about humans, but I feel I should tell you everything I want to say.

Yànpíng moves back to where he had stood before, right next to the other bird. Their wings rubbing against each other, with feathers puffing out.

Yanping: So ... you are leaving too.

Yanping: Well, it's only a matter of time. Good luck.

Getian's Clan Mate: Thank you.

In a rare moment of silence in the tree. One of the birds stretches his wing to cover the other.

Getian's Clan Mate: You're still unwilling to leave the mountain ... Is it because you can't bear to stay away from home?

Yanping: I simply have not found a reason to leave.

Getian's Clan Mate: Your time has not yet come, I guess, but that's fine, we need someone to take care of our nests and belongings ... I'll leave my books and instruments to you.

Getian's Clan Mate: You are the first one born in the Central Plains after we migrated. I think you will adapt to the environment here faster than we do.

Getian's Clan Mate: We are so used to living high in the sky. When we look down, both the cities and the people are no different from dirt piles. Only by living among them can we truly experience the prosperity described in the poems.

Getian's Clan Mate: I think you will leave the mountain one day.

Yanping: But not for now, at least.

Yanping: It's not yet time for me to think of such things.

Getian's Clan Mate: Just as well ... You glide slowly just like always.

Getian's Clan Mate: Hopefully I'll be useful to our people one day. I don't want to become another lazy bone always snoozing beneath the tree ...

The seasons changed, beasts and birds came and went away. And the traces they had left behind were gone in less than a day as the leaves fell.

The stream flows downwards and the wind blows its course night and day as always.

Yanping: You've returned.

Bone Collector: Hmm, who ... Ah, it's you, Yànpíng.

Yanping: Whose bones are these?

Bone Collector: Not your friends', I'm afraid.

Bone Collector: I will take them all to our temple. You may check them yourself should you wish.

Yanping: I will.

Bone Collector: Quite some time has passed. Yet, still you choose not to leave the mountain.

Bone Collector: Well, given the situation of our race, I guess you will be the last one left to take care of our bones.

Bone Collector: You will have to leave one day.

Yanping: I thank you for the reminder. Now, please leave me alone.

The bird robed in loose clothing stretches its wings and flies towards the point of a roof far away.

Yanping: ... It is fine weather for a nap.

Yanping: Both the mountain and the human world are between the sky and the earth. Are they really different?

Yanping: Anyway, the breeze feels comfortable now. I should take a nap.

Yanping: There are so many bones left in the temple. It could take a hundred years or even more to read through each one's stories.

Yanping: I might have a long life, but I'd still rather spend that time on the things I'm actually interested in.

Yanping: These stories have nothing to do with me.

Yanping: There is no need for me to leave the mountain.

The beasts in the mountain remained there for several generations, until the rocks in the stream had been polished smooth.

But the scholar tree where the birds rested remained as green as ever.

Yanping: Our kind has not had a new generation for a long time.

Yanping: I don't think anyone will be able to collect my bones and move them to the temple if I die outside this mountain.

Yanping: In that case, then the tombs here would eventually be buried by weeds.

Yanping: We migrated and followed the humans. We studied from different cultures. We put so much effort into prolonging the lives of our people.

Yanping: Yet it was all in vain, as I expected.

What eventually led him to leave the mountain was a summoning. In layman's terms, it was like a wordless awareness or calling.

Every member of his race would have felt it. Whenever it happened, they each would fold their wings and lower their heads, and the bone collector would set off to where the bones lay.

Yanping: Better make it quick.

Yanping: It's not far. Good, it's not too close to the human city. I won't be interrupted.

Yanping: He must have been on his way back to the mountain ... but didn't make it.

Yanping: No matter. I'll take him back.

From his view high in the sky, spotting the white bones strewn across the green foliage was a simple matter.

Seeing his target, he folded his wings and landed.

Yanping: We meet again.

He examined the skull beneath the cloth, and felt for a second it peered back at him. The wilderness was silent, as if the place were long abandoned.

Like how they used to, he kept a bit of a distance, but this time the bones did not hop forward to meet him.

One wing covered the other again.

Yanping: You know, I often wondered why every bone collector would eventually leave the mountain, just as you did. Was it the scenery, the people ... something else?

Yanping: You left to help humans build cities and bridges. You even sought out water sources and gave them your so-called advice.

Yanping: What is your purpose?

There was no reply. He hadn't cast the arcane skill that might allow the skull to speak.

Yànpíng lowered his head and found a line of ants climbing through a hole in the skull.

Yanping: To verify that you have learned the right knowledge? To offer help to the creatures similar to you?

Yanping: ...

Yanping: Or you just simply could not resist the desire to do so?

Yànpíng stayed there with the silent bones for a long time. Before he took wing again.

Yanping: No matter.

Yanping: "All men, whether great or ordinary, will end up a pile of bones." There's nothing else I can say.

Yanping: It's time to return.

6#1

Want Something

CH16603-03

Yanping: For as long as we draw breath we're migrating, and then at the moment of our death, we are reduced to bones in an instant. Thus, we take our people's bones with us wherever we move. It is our way.

Yanping: This wand not merely a tool to me.

Lizheng: So then the bone came from ...

Yanping: My clan mate's wing.

Yanping: I learned how to carve from humans, so that I might make this wand.

He reads the old man's reaction, hoping he might capture some clue from his response.

The old man raises his eyebrows, mouth slightly open but wordless, eyes open and fixed straight on him. It is shock.

Yanping: My apologies, if I've caused offense. There may be cultural differences between us ...

Lizheng: So then you're a bone carver! What a surprise!

Yanping: ...?

Lizheng: I know of a place that would be perfect for you!

Lizheng: It is called Nizhny Novgorod. Cool name, isn't it? There are many craftsmen there, and they make lions, tigers, reindeer, and even dragons out of bones! Their handicrafts are used as accessories on sheaths.

Lizheng: Can you imagine that? Legendary creatures coming to life through simple engravings on old bones ...

Yanping: Calm yourself, sir.

Yanping: Otherwise, I think I may have to cast a calming arcane skill.

Lizheng: Oh, please! Don't worry. I'm totally fine. I'm not rabid! I'm only happy for you.

Lizheng: Ah, but I almost forgot, I promised to tell you everything, so I don't think you would like to see this false image anymore.

Lizheng: Please hold on a second.

A second later, the old man's image fades away like a drop of ink in water.

The face revealed beneath is surprisingly young.

He tidies up his appearance, already decent enough, and begins again more seriously.

???: Alright. Please allow me to introduce myself one more time.

Leonid: You may call me "Leonid," "Hey, you," or "Employee," the name doesn't matter. Just pick one to make communication easier.

Leonid: I work for the St. Pavlov Foundation. I don't think you would know of it, but it's an organization which provides support for arcanists and collects their information. So far it has helped countless arcanists.

Leonid: I work at the Russian branch. Like the other branches, we are committed to helping arcanists. It's part of our duty.

Leonid: For example, if you are attacked by critters when you take a nap on the park bench, call us—but try to make sure you hadn't just drank too much vodka first.

Leonid: In truth, I love this job. It gives me the opportunities to get in touch with new things and people ...

Leonid: Like you, a rare case even among arcanists.

Leonid: I owe you an apology, to be honest. We were going to catch those big critters with corn and wheat. You know, they haunt this place in winter. Never expected to see you here.

Leonid: We thought you were a new species, but you are ... half man? So they called me here, just in case.

Gětiān has little sense of most of the technical jargon the now young man is speaking, but manages to capture the key information.

Yanping: Please, you don't have to do anything. It was I who ate the crops without permission. I should repay you for them.

Yanping: So how much are they?

Leonid: Oh, only a few Sharpodonties. It's already forgotten. Now back to bone carving, seriously ...

Yanping: Please ... wait. What is this "Sharpodonty"?

Leonid: A currency widely used by arcanists. I heard it has become popular even in the East now. Have you never seen one before?

Yanping: If you mean the things people use to "trade," the one I usually see is a round coin made of copper, with a hole in the middle. Though where I am from, many people simply barter.

They look into each other's eyes, each bewildered, not sure what to say next.

They're two very different creatures each from a very different culture.

Leonid: Well, I'm not sure I see how to carry on our current conversation. Let's stop the Artificial Somnambulism and find another place to talk.

Leonid: Please close your eyes ... I'll take you to a room where we can sit.

Yanping: Alright.

Leonid: The corridors of our branch can be kind of narrow. You may find your wings brushing along the wall.

Yanping: I will be careful.

Leonid: I have another question.

Yanping: By all means, go ahead.

Leonid: It seems there is no language barrier between us. Is that part of your arcane skill?

Leonid: By the way, that grain you ate was soaked in liquor, you were passed out drunk when we found you. We mistook you for a strange critter, but then your wand glowed, my colleagues screamed as if a pack of bears or moose had broken loose in our branch again ...

Leonid: I had to confiscate it for now, and I took your pendant too, just in case.

Yanping: I ... yes, our languages, it's my arcane skill working. I apologize for you finding me in that sorry scene.

Leonid: More than fine with it, our team didn't suffer any trouble, we've seen worse ... Ah! Here, we are.

The austere room places metal wherever one might expect wood, leaving the room with a monochromatic gray hue.

The layout imposes a feeling of strictness and cold.

Combing through the experiences he's witnessed through others' bones, Gětiān can only think of one place that would look this way.

Yanping: Is this a prison?

Leonid: Haha, you know, I told them to use more colors in the room, but they didn't listen!

Leonid: This is, sadly, a bog-standard office of the Foundation. You've caught on to its biggest drawback—it does give the impression of a prison to anyone with even the slightest care for aesthetics.

Leonid: Maybe it's to make us more eager in the field ... Who knows? Please take a seat.

He pulls out a chair for the bird, gesturing for him to sit, then sits on the opposite side.

Something round drops from between his fingers and onto the table.

Leonid: This is a Sharpodonty. Hold it if you want. Just be careful, it might bite you.

Yanping: It looks similar to the coins I know, only without a hole in the middle.

Yanping: It seems your kind have a preference for cats.

Leonid: It's a lion, a much larger animal! Imagine a cat larger than this table, with mane and a loud roar.

Leonid: Hey!

Leonid grabs the Sharpodonty immediately and puts it in his pocket.

The pocket continues to make a racket of gnashing teeth and ineffectual anger.

Yanping: This is a splendid coin. It would be most difficult to steal.

Leonid: Yes, though ... I never thought it would bite you. Usually Sharpodonties only bite humans or when irritated.

Leonid: You look like a decent ... bird.

Yanping: I wonder if a lion likes being petted, like a cat does.

He admits to himself, frankly, that he likes being petted too.

Leonid: You've come a long way from home though, that makes me think you're the curious type.

Leonid: Now, before we move on, I must clarify that the Foundation does not intend to violate the privacy of any arcanists.

Leonid: The following questions are based on the information I have collected from the Artificial Somnambulism. It's a special circumstance and I hope you understand.

Leonid: To show my sincerity, here's your wand.

He takes out a long bone stick from a hidden place and pushes towards the awkwardly seated bird.

Leonid: You've shown some trust in me, so I think I should trust you in return.

Leonid: Few would close their eyes in front of an arcanist they just met without hesitation.

Yanping: Your bones told me that you are a straightforward person, all deceptions aside.

Yanping: They also say there is something you want from me. That's why you are being so friendly.

Gětiān leaves the wand on the table, waiting for Leonid's response patiently.

After all, he received many such offers of kindness from the people beyond his mountain.

Whoever they were, they all shared one thing in common: there was always something they wanted.

There is always a motive behind a stranger's kindness.

Yanping: What do you want? Wealth, fame, social status, or a new arcane skill?

Yanping: People like you have similar purposes.

6#1

Part Ways

CH16603-04

The young man nods, looking much as the bird expected.

Yet his barrage of questions catches Gětiān off-guard.

Leonid: So how might I make this wish? Is there a ritual one needs to perform? And how is it that you grant these wishes?

Leonid: And is it true that you are capable of bringing abundance, like the legendary Firebird?

Leonid: Or are you Koshchei himself, merely hiding in a bird's body?

Leonid sounds very familiar with these names, his face containing a joyful smile as he mentions them.

Leonid: Anyway, whatever creature you are, I would like to ask you for a story.

Yanping: A story?

Leonid: Yes, a story you didn't finish.

Leonid: You told me the backstory of your wand. And it already revealed much about your people. I appreciate you letting me peek into your people's lives like that.

Leonid: So I wish that you would finish it. And if you need something in return, I will tell you anything you like, or everything even, so long as it's not classified.

Leonid: I enjoy collecting all kinds of stories and finding out the truth behind them, and especially a legend from the Eastern land we know so little about.

Leonid: If you're wondering at my motive, your information will undoubtably be important to the Foundation. It may even prove useful for my career.

Yanping: So in the end, you are seeking a higher status.

Leonid: Not truly, no. But, if you'd like to think of it that way, I don't mind.

The man shrugs his shoulders, before leaning back in towards Gětiān.

Leonid: You were reluctant to leave that mountain in your story, but now here we are talking in this room. Why did you leave? Did your curiosity finally get the better of you?

Leonid: Your story will answer my questions, and perhaps my intel could be useful for you in turn.

Yanping: I asked myself that question many times. And never arrived on a simple answer ...

Yanping: But I don't mind giving it a try.

Yanping: But as you said, we are exchanging information that may be useful to the other, and I have provided some of mine. It's your turn now.

Leonid: I guess you'll ask me about the Foundation, right?

Yanping: I believe I understand that your "Foundation" is like the "Zhící" in my homeland, an authority at the least.

Yanping: And that your arcane skill is of a rare kind and talent.

Yanping: The image was so real that I hadn't doubted it until the very end. Such a skill could only be the result of generations of cultivation, I'm sure.

Yanping: But I've only seen it once among the bones I've seen. So where did you learn it from?

Leonid: I'm afraid I have to disappoint you. What you saw wasn't an arcane skill at all. I don't know that any arcanist in our foundation could do this with arcane skills alone, not even our best.

Leonid: No, what you saw here was produced by a machine, given a little ingenuity on our part. Though I admit, it probably looks like magic to most people.

Leonid: Officially, it's called "Artificial Somnambulism."

Yanping: Yes, I remember, you mentioned it before.

Leonid: The city, the old man, and the ladies I asked you about were all produced from your memories. Your subconscious tricked you into rationalizing what you saw as real.

Leonid: Essentially, you built the dream around yourself, so it's only natural that you believed it was real.

The bird tries to match Leonid's words with his experiences.

This machine must be some kind of mechanical device.

And his subconsciousness must refer to the impressions of one's own mind.

And if that is the case, the function of this "Artificial Somnambulism" becomes obvious.

Yanping: So this device reads one's mind and creates an illusion using replicas built from one's own memories. In a way, it functions quite similar to the arcane skill I had seen before.

Leonid: From the sounds of it, yes, but please don't be alarmed.

Leonid: The Artificial Somnambulism Guidance has specified the scope of content that operators are allowed to access. We can't see the parts of your mind that you refuse to show, not that we would ever try. It would be a severe violation of one's personal rights, after all.

Leonid: You're a rare case, I had access to that entire city and all those people in your mind. Not to imply you are careless, but it seems you trust others easily.

Leonid: I guess your hometown has a friendly and tolerant atmosphere.

Yanping: No ... Not exactly.

Yanping: That's one of the reasons why I left the mountain.

Yanping: Much of what I know comes from my people's bones, but there is a limit to what I can learn. I cannot know what they've forgotten or what they refuse to tell.

Yanping: But I find myself more than a little confused as we continue our conversation.

Yanping: You desire something, yet refuse to admit it. You invented a method to read people's mind, yet impose so many restrictions on it.

Yanping: When my people left the mountain, humans begged them to grant their wishes, yet at the same time, they suspected my people of evil intentions.

Yanping: When my kind were still alive, some humans thought we were sent by their deities, while others grew bitter, thinking our help was demeaning.

Yanping: And as we died out, one by one, some cheered and some cried ...

Yanping: Now, I sense you have no intention to push me, yet you are not going to let me go either. You try to be nice and show sincerity, yet I sense a nervousness at my every movement.

Yanping: It seems you humans really are ... inconsistent.

Yanping: But what I do not understand is what this has to do with my homeland ...

Leonid: Inconsistent? Aha, yes, I suppose we can be ... but most people never question their own inconsistencies.

Leonid: But, I know this is no small question for you, and that's why I think we're in a position to help each other.

Leonid: If you tell me more about your home, then I'll have more of the information I need, and then maybe we can work out just why it is we humans can be so inconsistent.

Leonid: It's likely not every detail will be useful, but why not give it a try?

The young man leans forward again, like pressing a weight against the bird, hoping for a response.

Gětiān takes notice at that moment, that the young man's neck bones shine brighter whenever he mentions the legend from the east.

And now they are practically glowing.

Leonid: Please.

Yanping: ...

Leonid: I hope to hear everything that happened somewhere far away from here, and in the name of Leonid, I swear I will never use the story for any evil purposes.

Leonid: I know that word-of-mouth doesn't always ring true and that a story told from just one perspective can never give a full impression ...

Leonid: But I can't stop myself from chasing this story to its end.

The man's driving curiosity might have come off too strong, if Gětiān hadn't felt it himself before.

His race's arcane skill allowed them to read other creatures' minds, yet the animals of the mountain had little occupying their minds except their daily survival.

The birds didn't truly understand what being curious was like until they found a race with minds more like their own. Creatures that could communicate using words, that could invent and imagine new things.

From this race, the birds learned how to use fire and how to write down their thoughts, and finally they learned to be curious.

Now the bird suddenly realizes what he and the young man share in common.

Yanping: What attracts you is not necessarily good for you.

He held in a sigh.

Leonid: I see, but never knowing would be even worse for me.

Yanping: Very well. I already interpreted a Hexagram for my friends before I came here. It said, "One should go with the flow."

Yanping: So, I have decided that I will just "go with the flow."

Yanping: You haven't returned my pendant yet. Shall we start from there?

Leonid: I'm listening, and with great anticipation, let me say.

Yanping: In fact, its former owner was a bit like you.

Leonid: Really? I'm honored you'd say so ...

The young man cuts his reply short, prodding the bird to continue.

Yanping: But I suppose, when I think back on it ... it seems a trait that all humans share.

Gětiān glances at the young man, tilting his head.

Leonid can sense there is a compliment behind the bird's expression. As if he were an old man rustling a boy's hair with a smile.

Leonid: ...

Leonid: Could I ask how old you are? I don't know how to tell how old a bird looks, but you don't seem ... old.

Leonid: So ... would you be, say ... my father's age?

Yanping: No. Likely, not.

Leonid: Don't tell me you're as old as my grandfather!

Yanping: I'm much older than your great-great-grandfather, I'm afraid.

Leonid: ...!

The young man's confusion seems more natural to his face than his smile.

Taking a deep breath, the bird begins to tell the story.

Yanping: This jade pendant belonged to two others before it came to me.

6#1

Heart of Flesh

CH16603-05

Yanping: In my homeland, the people living under the mountain had a preference for jade wares.

Yanping: I can only scarcely remember when those delicate jade pendants first came into fashion in the city. They resembled their coins; rounded, with a hole in the center.

Yanping: Some were glossy green, others pale white. They would feel warm if kept close to the body.

Yanping: Perhaps that's why it was worth so much.

Yanping: I first saw it on the belt of a scholar.

Scholar: ... I ... pray ...

Scholar: ... keep us safe ... in this place ...

Yanping: What is that ...?

He raises his head from behind his wings and to look down through the leaves.

This is not the first time he has heard a human here.

Yanping: Another seeker of blessings.

Yanping: I wonder why they put so much trust in the power of this tree ...

Yanping: Perhaps they do this simply for peace of mind. I suppose it doesn't matter.

Citizen: Good day to you, young master. I've seen you up here a lot of late.

Citizen: Here to pray for the exam? You have shown good devotion. The tree fairy will surely look after you.

Scholar: I can only hope to be so blessed.

Scholar: I come here to pray every day, but I do so just to reassure myself, in case I become too nervous in the exam to remember what I have learned.

Citizen: You ought to play some music underneath the tree.

Citizen: People say they hear songs coming down from the tree, but no one has ever seen any bird or man playing it. We figure it's a fairy.

Citizen: And if you play music to please her, the fairy might give you her blessings.

Yanping: ...

Getian never expected he'd be the cause of a superstition.

He had just learned a song from the bones. It had been a quiet day, and he was practicing.

Who would have thought it could be so misconstrued?

Scholar: Wouldn't I be ... swaying the fairy's judgment if I did so?

Scholar: I should just say my wishes as they are. Then it's the fairy's choice to grant them or not.

They converse for a little longer, until the second voice begins to fade away.

Now the only voice is the one which woke him from his dream.

Scholar: I wish for the people here to live a life of peace, safe from disaster, and that their hard work will be rewarded with bountiful harvests ...

Scholar: ... that merchants will be safe on their journeys ...

Yanping: His wishes are all about others.

Yanping: How curious ...

He loses himself momentarily in thought before casting another glance down to him.

Yanping: That backbone ... He may make a good counselor in the court.

He rarely read other creatures' bones outside of his own people.

Bone reading so often makes one curious; and curiosity in turn could be the cause of many troubles.

Even when he wanted to read another creature's bones, he would inevitably talk himself out of it.

He tries, with some difficulty, to not make this an exception.

Yanping: Pity he will live a disturbed life. Over-righteousness often comes with misfortune.

Yanping: He will die for his beliefs. I cannot help but wonder if it might be a ...

Yanping: ... No. It's none of my concern.

Gětiān pulls back his glance from the man and his bones.

But the voice inches closer.

Scholar: I must set out tomorrow.

Scholar: Let me see. I don't have anything valuable, actually. I'll just leave this here, as a token of sincerity.

Scholar: I promise to return with better offerings to show my gratitude, well, if my wishes come true that is ...

Yanping: ...

As the man approaches the tree, the bird withdraws more deeply into its leaves.

There is a rustling of fabric and grass. Something is put on the ground.

Scholar: Right. This ... should do it.

Scholar: Farewell.

Gětiān cannot dare to look until all is quiet again.

Below him now is a jade pendant. The same that had hung on the young man's belt.

The bird ponders for a moment and puts it into the tree's hollow.

Yanping: Nobody will look inside the tree's hollow. It's safer here.

Yanping: And should he come back to look for it, I will find a way to return it to him.

Yanping: What is lost must be returned, so one may be spared unwanted troubles.

The thought puts his mind at ease. And he returns to his sleep.

Yanping: After the young scholar left, life in the forest became quiet again. I spent many long hours in that tree, napping or just listening to the wind.

Yanping: But the scholar never returned.

Yanping: Perhaps it is just as his bones foretold; and he was taken by death young.

Yanping: Even if I was wrong, mortal lives are short. The pendant no longer had a master.

Yanping: Until I met its second owner.

Scholar's Son: So this is the tree Father mentioned. It's more flourishing than I imagined.

Scholar's Son: I wouldn't be surprised if there truly was a fairy here.

Yanping: I hadn't seen many blessing-seekers for some time. It seemed now that people only gathered under the tree to talk and laugh before parting ways.

Yanping: Humans ...

Yanping: Hmm?

Seeing this young man recalls a similar scene.

His bones are strangely similar to those of the young scholar who visited so many years ago.

He foresees that this man too will meet a similar end.

Yanping: I thought people in the outside world cherished their lives more than anything. How come he would rather die than stand by? It's meaningless.

Yanping: Risking your life just to say something that might not even be adopted. How reckless! It's not worth it.

Yanping: Is this necessary?

For him, spending so much time in this tree, well perhaps it's merely habit ... But this is where the humans come to make their wishes.

And he listens to their requests, trying to understand what draws his race to them.

He no longer blames his people for leaving home behind. Still, he is puzzled.

... Why did you go into the human world? Why did you sacrifice yourself?

Scholar's Son: Father, the places you used to talk about, I visited them all.

Scholar's Son: You warned me not to follow in your footsteps. But I chose this path on my own.

Scholar's Son: Besides, I have already seen the beauty of the world. I can't bear to watch it being ruined.

Gětiān listens silently from the treetop.

This had been the moment to return the pendant.

Scholar's Son: Such a beautiful tree should stay here alone, so it won't be destroyed.

Scholar's Son: Enough empty words. I've made up my mind.

The young man walks away with determination. Never looking back.

The bird knows at that moment he will never see him again.

From then on, he found himself returning to the hollow to check on the pendant.

Within a few short days his prediction appears to come true.

Yanping: As I thought.

Yanping: What could he have gained from this desperate course of action?

Yanping: ...

The jade, now broken, seems like little more than a mound of pebbles. But the bird picks them up.

Yanping: I tried to repair it. Doing the best I could, afterward I tied it to the end of my bone flute.

Yanping: I thought maybe I would come to understand them more by repairing the jade.

Yanping: They struggled for what they knew was impossible, and even died for it unknowingly, just like my people.

Yanping: Not long after that, a strange rumor went around the village—that people there were being mysteriously turned into horses.

Yanping: I decided to find out what really happened.

Yanping: Turns out I am also part of the story.

6#1

The Limited Sky in the Teapot

CH16603-06

Leonid: So you repaired the pendant ... that's why it has these cracks?

Leonid: I wouldn't have thought it possible with just a pair of wings. Holding it at a distance, you can hardly tell it was broken.

Following his gaze down, the bird's eyes spot the jade lying on the table.

Yanping: I have not checked it carefully in a very long time. Judging from the look, I might have spent a lot of effort on it indeed.

Yanping: I felt something change inside me, after seeing what happened to the previous owners of the pendant. So when I left the mountain, I kept it as a reminder.

Leonid: Not to meddle in others' affairs?

Yanping: And to remind myself how similar my people and humans really are ...

Leonid: I wasn't favored by the goddess of wisdom. So please forgive me if I say anything stupid or offensive.

Softly and tentatively, he touches the edge of the pendant with his fingertips. Then he sits up.

Leonid: It feels a little like a piece of bone. Speaking of which, I wonder what you can see from my bones ... No. Never mind. I don't think I want to know.

Leonid: At first, I thought it was a trick for detecting lies and illusions. But if it's my past and future that you are seeing, count me out.

Leonid: I would lose interest in living my life if I find out that I won't die surrounded by my collections of stories and beautifully carved bones.

Yanping: I haven't looked that closely.

Leonid: You "haven't"! But it IS within your abilities to pry into the details. Please don't tell anyone what you see, including me. Clamp it, muzzle it! Oh ... Pardon me. I only mean your ability is very impressive. Yes. That's all I wanted to say.

Yanping: You flatter me, sir.

Yanping: But life beyond the mountain has told me much more than what the bones may tell. My people must have felt the same as they traveled across the human world.

Yanping: They thought themselves visitors to that world, only traveling through it, little did they know that they were already bound to it.

Yanping: But things are connected once they meet each other.

Yanping: Novelty attracts attention, and it is all too easy to get obsessed with finding it.

Yanping: I learned calligraphy, drawing, music instruments ... so many other skills. I have also learned many poems, all thanks to chasing novelty.

Leonid: I started carving bones after I got this very knife.

Leonid: Actually, the bone piece embedded in the blade will shine like a pearl if you put it under the light ... but there's no doubt it's bone. It even looks alive when you put it in fire ... I just can't stop looking at it.

Leonid: Do your people know how to do it?

Yanping: Do what?

Leonid: Imbue things with life.

Leonid: Wood, bones, metal, mud ... We may shape them into the forms of animals and men—this is one way of bringing them to life.

Leonid: The other way is ... to give them stories.

Leonid: When I first saw your bone wand and the jade pendant, I assumed that the wand was more precious than the pendant, because it has arcane power, and the pendant doesn't.

Leonid: But now, I'm more drawn in to your pendant's story.

Leonid: Items with stories are more valuable than those without.

Yanping: Indeed.

Leonid: And to fully master a skill, one must first find a good teacher, and then be willing to search the world to learn more ...

He stops himself.

Leonid: Oh. Sorry, I should get some water. Or would you like tea? I'm going to brew some anyway.

Leonid: The branch just bought some new samovars. I'll make some tea for us.

A shiny tea set now fills up most of the space on the desk. The young man bends down to carefully light the charcoal beneath the device.

Yanping: How convenient. The pot must come from a good designer.

Leonid: My people are heavy tea-drinkers, so samovars were invented to meet our needs. It's very convenient, it pours easily and provides much needed wind protection to keep the tea warm. There's even a place to set snacks on.

Leonid: You see, no one would have been bothered to design such a thing if tea weren't introduced to us.

The glistening, amber tea is poured out of the pot until it fills the cup. As the steam rises, drops of water condense on the tips of the bird's feathers.

Leonid: If there are needs, there will be those who try to meet those needs.

Leonid: It's true, once you have a prototype, others will try to improve on it. But ...

Leonid: The "creation" is the real exciting part.

The bird ruminates on the word.

The young man is right. His people have never developed any skills or invented anything—not even the smallest things which might make their lives easier, like this tea pot.

All they have ever done is imitation or mimicry.

They spent years learning human languages, imitating their behaviors, and adapting to their customs. The bones of their predecessors, recording all the information they would need.

Yanping: Neither I nor any of my people have ever "created" anything.

Yanping: If imitation was what we left the mountain for, we probably chose the wrong path at the very beginning.

Yanping: It's meaningless.

He puts an end to this thought.

It's a conclusion he never thought he would make, but not one he never thought about before.

Leonid: Don't overthink it! True invention is rare, only a small number of people ever manage it. There are as few of them as an old man's hair!

Leonid: Someone else invented it, and now all I have to do is make the tea.

Yanping: Anyone can make tea.

Leonid: True, true ... but we all brew our tea a little differently. Each taste is unique.

Leonid: I have to say, your dogged pursuit of an explanation reminds me of some of my other arcanist friends ...

Leonid: I don't know how to make a wand as simple and natural as yours; likewise, you can't make tea as good as mine. Things like this happen all the time. It's not a big deal.

Leonid: There's no need to dwell on the true reason you left the mountain. Maybe it was just curiosity. It could be anything!

Leonid: Or perhaps you were looking for a tool to survive.

Yanping: We don't need any new tools, my people have always had what we needed to survive.

Leonid: Now, now. With that mindset, you're sure to find yourself at a dead end. How could I make tea without a samovar? You'll have to see more to know what you're capable of, what you're made to do! That's your "tool."

The young man shakes his head a little, and takes a sip from his cup. His face wrinkling up in disgust.

Leonid: *spits the tea out* It's bitter!

Leonid: Don't ... Oh, good that you haven't had any. Too many tea leaves in one pot, I'd say!

Leonid: I'll make you another one.

Yanping: No matter. Allow me.

Leonid: ... Oh ... Well ... Thank you.

Yanping: Sugar or honey?

Leonid: Honey, please. That's how we had it back in the village.

The bird nods in understanding. He stares at the tea pot and slightly lifts his wings. The bronze pot tilts as he moves, and deftly fills their cups.

Leonid: Oh, and please pour my tea here, into the plate.

As he waits for his tea, the young man scoops up some honey and sends it into his mouth. Then he takes up his plate, drinking the tea from its edge.

Yanping: I've never seen one drink tea in this manner before.

Leonid: You'll get used to it if you stick around. We don't have rules on how people should drink their tea here.

Yanping: Indeed, it's good to learn new things.

The white steam from the hot tea rises, and they both fall into a comfortable silence.

Slowly, the steam gathers until it hangs in the air like fog. As Leonid realizes he no longer can see Gětiān's face, nor the wall behind him.

But there is still a wall, only it's no longer the staid gray office walls he knew.

Leonid: What is going on?!

Leonid: You said you don't know anything about Artificial Somnambulism. So how did you gain access to it? You ...

Yanping: I have no such device in my possession. I spoke truly, I had never experienced its effects before.

Yanping: But I did tell you of an arcane skill similar to it. Have you forgotten?

Leonid: ...

Leonid: It's my job to assess whether you are a threat to the Foundation. To do that, I had to keep certain information from you. We only want honest answers from you, that's all.

Leonid: Now ... You're right, we are still dreaming. That was the last piece of information I kept from you.

Leonid: If you're upset ...

Yanping: I knew what you wanted since the beginning.

The bird's voice is calm as he continues.

Yanping: Yet, I was bewildered by the inconsistency between your words and your deeds.

Yanping: I have also learned much from our conversation. But as I was once told, it is best to judge the heart by its deeds.

Yanping: ... Which is why I'm taking control.

6#1

No More Astray

CH16603-07

Leonid: Turns out I was the one who was left in the dark ...

Leonid: Now I wonder why you let me guide you into these dreams. Weren't you afraid? As I'm afraid now. The Foundation won't go easy on me if they find out you operated the machine without training! And what if anything goes wrong, and we're stuck in here forever?

Yanping: You have an interest in handicrafts.

Leonid: Hm? Oh! A sudden change of topic. Y-yes, of course. I wasn't lying to you ...

Yanping: I made note of the place you mentioned ...

Leonid: You did? That's good. In fact, if you ever go there, do you mind bringing me a couple of things ...

Yanping: ... And I'm hoping you might remember this place of mine.

Yanping: We are born with the talents of speaking human language and reading bones. Our bodies are a combination of humans and birds. They will turn into skeletons as soon as we die.

Yanping: It is my people's belief that we should witness as many beings and events as we can. To record them in our bones while we are still alive.

Yanping: And after our death, our bones will be taken to our next home.

Yanping: We moved from the borderlands to the Central Plains because of war.

Yanping: Our future changed dramatically not long after we'd arrived. Then, one by one, my people left the mountain; now more and more bones are brought back, and with the bones come rumors ... tales about us.

Yanping: People in the human world call us Mièméngs,

Yanping: yet we prefer to call the entire race by one surname, which is Gětiān.

Yanping: And I am the first Gětiān ever born in the Central Plains.

A mountain breeze rises, gentler than the icy wind of the land where they had been, it rustles through both hair and feathers.

They hear the footsteps of animals on soft earth, the patter of tree branches, and the humming of water in a brook.

Getian: For a very long time, I simply roosted on this tree.

Getian: As the days passed, fewer and fewer of my people visited me. Most had become the lazy bones lying in the temple.

Getian: The bones never lied about their owner's character. Some could be talkative, some were taciturn.

Getian: The lives of mortals then scarcely intrigued me, but the life in the mountain had grown dull in equal measure.

Getian: Until a thought dawned on me: though humans cannot read bones, they have their own ways to pass on memories.

Getian: They write, or draw; they compose music, they shape mud and earth or carve solid stone ...

Getian: I have mastered all these skills and read the lives of my people, almost every one of them. I will make an attempt.

Leonid: What are you going to show me? A room full of treasures?

Getian: A room with only lifeless objects.

Getian: Please come in.

Getian: My wand is made of bone, the bone from one of my people. He had taken a lot of trouble on my behalf before I left the mountain.

Getian: His bones were never returned to this temple; for a long time, I assumed he was alive somewhere far beyond the mountain. Until one day I overheard the bones speaking, and they mentioned where his remains lied.

Getian: The temple he last stayed at was not far away from the city. The place was long deserted ... He gave up his life, neither wanting to return to his people nor to be remembered and worshiped into posterity.

Getian: I didn't understand his choice.

Getian: I choose not to take him back to our temple, as he wished it to be. But I took his story home, to write it down in one of these scrolls.

Leonid: This isn't a very large room, but it would be some effort to find anything specific.

Aided only by the dim light seeping in from the outside, Leonid squints at the collections waiting in the dark.

Some things are hung in the air, while others appear casually tossed aside. Barely visible in the dark clutter; bones and carvings, losing their dull luster to age.

Leonid: How are you going to find the right scroll in a dark room like this?

Getian: Not a concern.

The bird turns his head and the room is suddenly basked in warm lamp light.

Getian: "Who can tell the difference between the bones of the great and those of the ordinary? One should seek the pleasure of life, not the future after death."

Although the language he speaks is completely unfamiliar to him, the young man seems to understand the meaning of each word.

It dawns on him that Gětiān is continuing to use his powers to keep their conversation smooth and clear.

Leonid: That's true. Whatever we have done when we are alive, we will become a pile of bones after we die.

He looks around and gasps out of amazement.

Leonid: Your collections ... and these works. I'm amazed.

Leonid: You truly are one of the best craftsme- er, birds, I've ever seen.

Getian: Is that so?

Getian: Thank you.

The temple is quiet. Words are unnecessary here, for they are useless to the dead.

The only sounds in the room are Gětiān's feathers brushing across the scrolls.

6#1

After the Endless Plain

CH16603-08

The tea is still warm; as if the people there had never left the room.

Leonid: Phew. Home safe. No one's brain is permanently wrecked. Thank goodness.

Leonid: But I'd never regret taking this journey with you, sir.

Leonid: Earlier, you said your name was Yànpíng ... But you call yourself Gětiān, after your people, so what do I call you?

Getian: If you don't mind, simply call me "Gětiān."

He pauses for a moment, and solemnly speaks the young man's name.

Getian: Leonid.

Leonid: Yes? I'm listening.

Getian: Is that your true name?

Leonid: Oh. Like I said in the beginning, names aren't important. We use them only for the sake of communication ... Hope mine is not too tough to remember.

Leonid: If you wish to know the name I usually go with ... My other colleagues always refer to me as "Name Day."

A second introduction. Like a handshake from a friend.

Getian: I see.

Name Day: A toast to you, Mr. Gětiān.

The young man raises his cup.

Name Day: To peace.

Getian: ... To peace.

The bird extends his wing and pushes his cup towards the man. The man lowers his.

The cups reach each other, making a single clink.

Name Day: It's still nagging at me. When did you figure out that we were dreaming?

Getian: The very moment you appeared as "Lǐzhèng."

Name Day: How ... Did I do something wrong?

Getian: No. It was only that you asked me about my friends' whereabouts.

Getian: It was odd that you'd ask.

Getian: And that besides, your bones were a poor match to his appearance.

Getian: Illusions are difficult to perform, much like this Artificial Somnambulism. With diligent practice, you might become very good indeed.

Name Day: Now you do sound like someone who's centuries old.

Name Day: Let me get all the information sorted out, hopefully I will have some time left to show you around in the branch. The one in reality, of course.

Getian: Take your time.

But the man busily digging into his files seems not to hear him.

Name Day: I'll put you down as ... "not hostile." In fact, you are kind, sensible, and very pleasant to converse with.

Name Day: But I will have to ask that question again.

Name Day: Please don't worry. My job is done, so your answer won't affect your assessment.

Getian: I see. Finish what you have started.

Name Day: When we first met, I asked you which was more important to you, the bone wand or the jade pendant.

Name Day: At that time, I was only trying to figure out if you had a preference. One perhaps you shared with humans and arcanists.

Name Day: But you already answered that through your stories: you treat them both as equals. Just as you value the wand and pendant.

Name Day: Are you sure you value them equally? What if you have to give up either of them to survive one day?

Getian: As we talked, I worried whether you might take the wand and the pendant from me.

He looks into the young man's eyes.

Getian: I told myself you meant no harm. You only wanted to learn more about me.

Getian: From my story, you should know there is always a third option for me ...

Getian: I would have traded my life for them.

Getian: If I had to make a choice between the wand and the pendant, I would give you my bones.

Name Day: Your bones.

Slowly, he repeats the words and nods.

Name Day: I didn't expect that answer.

He closes his notebook, and rises to push the chair back under the table, before turning around.

Name Day: Please wait another moment. I need to pause the Artificial Somnambulism program first and bring you back to the waking world as the protocol requested.

Name Day: I wish you a wonderful journey from here on. Your registration documents will be issued shortly.

Name Day: Not long before, we encountered a poet from an island. Perhaps you will see him too in the future; I think you'd have a great time together.

Getian: I will look forward to it.

Name Day: Also ... I didn't lie about my love of stories. Should you hear more during your journey, I hope you might share them with me.

Name Day: Can you write with your wings? Like using a quill pen.

Getian: I will attempt to do so.

The bird raises his wing; performing something as close to a wave as he can do.

Getian: Goodbye.

Finally returning to his solitude. The bird preens himself while enjoying the peace of the moment.

He has seen and heard so much since he left the mountain, but rarely took the time to look back on his stories.

The tea, the ink, the paper. The metal pot, the wooden table, the stone paved road. So many things he had never seen in the mountains.

He was a newborn chick, and the mountain, the brook, and the forest were his shell. Now the shell has been gently cracked, and he flows out into a bowl.

That bowl might be roughly made, but the liquid inside is clear and good, reflecting the sky, the mountains, and everything ...

Getian: Perhaps this explains why people in the human world love liquor.

Getian: I should have drunk with them, when I had the chance.

The bird closes his eyes.

There is still time to enjoy the moment, before he wakes up from this dream.

Getian: Life beyond the mountain is indeed chaotic.

Getian: I never intended to stay long in the city after that transformation mystery was solved.

Getian: But now, I'm even further away from home.

Getian: Perhaps I will never return home again.

Getian: Even so it was good to see it once more ... if only in a dream.

Gětiān sits on the scholar tree, just as he had before. With the wind still blowing through his feathers.

But he feels now that he is no longer as he was.

Getian: If time went back to that day, I would still fly down the mountain.

Getian: The owner of that tavern was young. Stubborn, because of her youth. But she has always been true to herself.

Getian: She grew up in that city, growing close to her neighbors, she loved them like they were her own kin.

Getian: If she did jump over that bridge, she must be a real Xiángruì now. She must be pleased.

Getian: As for those two foreign merchants, they weren't scared away by all the trouble. They stayed till the very end.

Getian: That day, I saw the lanterns floating down the river glowing brighter than ever before.

Getian: And that Hexagram of Water and Fire. The choice to be made. Xū, with water above and sky below. The Hexagram of waiting.

Getian: I hope they left the city with what they wanted. Till this day, I still wonder which path that lady with unreadable bones ultimately chose.

Getian: That young man was another interesting person. I wonder whom I will meet next.

Getian: How would I know the limits of the mountain if I didn't leave it? Yet the world turns out to be another bowl.

Getian: Fine. I shall listen to the wind before anything comes up.

6#2